While an array of Americans sought postwar Paris for their own self-imposed exile in Europe or mined the contradictions of domestic culture traveling the interstate highway system on the American open road, this book reveals that the divided city of Berlin was another option for Americans seeking a critical distance. To identify or be adopted as an "American Berliner" was to conjure the symbolic links between American and German division, in a way, akin to President Kennedy's assertion of symbolic Berlin citizenship, but inclusive of his brother's acknowledgment of the walls of segregation while in the city. The American Berliners at the center of this book are culture producers whose shared focus on divided Berlin informed their sustained, critical engagement with American and German historical ideas, places, problems, and modes of power and belonging. Along with other cities occupied by the Cold War cultural imagination and American military forces alike, Berlin brought into sharp relief the crises of democracy in the United States and beyond. The cohort of critically engaged artists, writers, and activists at the center of this book experienced divided Berlin and approached their time in the city to also better understand the contours and dividing lines of American culture. They were drawn to make sense of Berlin's traumatized past, its militarized present, and its experiments in rebuilding democracy after the chaos of fascism and war.

As self-appointed agents to explore the dynamics of cultural division, American Berliners were prompted or fueled by their experiences by the Wall to produce enduring artworks, publications, and projects about division in American culture through their participation in and perpetuation of what I suggest as Berlin's "circuits of alternative cultural diplomacies." They, too, considered the "walls of their own," to repurpose and reprioritize thinking on division in context with the Berlin Wall. They helped complicate Berlin's place in the cultural imaginary of the United States, and vice versa, in nuanced and meaningful ways. Together, these artists, writers, and activists, and the many others who similarly dwell within this larger history, exemplify a tradition of engaged American travel and critical thinking within footsteps of the Berlin Wall, in a city epitomized by its cycles of freedom and repression. They took no solace in the Wall's existence and the militarized reality that surrounded it. They did, however, approach the Wall physically and conceptually to transform the division as